Mohan makes a related point about the need to claim authority rather than waiting for it to be conferred. She rejects the tendency to praise women primarily for managing people or keeping operations running smoothly. "I don't want to be known as a woman who manages things well. I want to be known as a leader who builds things well," she says.

The distinction matters in sectors where women leaders can be associated with support functions even when their remit includes decisions central to business performance. Building the business, in this view, means being recognised for strategy, execution and results, not just the ability to coordinate people.

At Zen, Choudari's account is less about confronting gender directly than expanding her own sense of what she can do. She describes herself as an introvert who did not initially imagine she would occupy a senior role. Her growing confidence came through experience, exposure and responsibility.

The four accounts do not suggest one universal model of women's leadership. They show women arriving at authority through different routes—founding a company, taking on operational responsibilities, progressing across functions, and building organisational systems.

PROGRESS, NOT COMPLETE

The wider data points to movement in women's participation in management, alongside persistent gaps in the conditions that help them advance. The numbers indicate faster growth in managerial participation. They do not, by themselves, establish that women now hold an equal share of management roles.

The AIMA–KPMG report, *Women Leadership in Corporate India 2026*, based on insights from more than 200 professionals, highlights the gap between progress in representation and the experience of advancement. It finds that 55% of employees surveyed acknowledge having a defined process for assessing candidates for leadership roles, but only 28% believe that the evaluation process is genuinely fair and transparent. It also identifies work-life pressures, burnout, caregiving responsibilities and uneven access to leadership opportunities as factors shaping women's career trajectories.

These findings matter because a growing number of women entering management does not automatically mean they have equal access to high-impact assignments, decision-making authority or opportunities needed to progress into senior leadership. Nor does representation alone tell us whether organisations are equipped to retain and develop that talent.

The leaders' accounts bring these institutional questions into focus. Rangarajan's emphasis on process and employee ownership, Choudari's evolution into a broader operational role, Mohan's focus on autonomy and accountability, and Sardana's attempt to formalise an informal market all point to the organisational work that accompanies growth. Their approaches are not identical. Neither should their experiences be flattened into a single narrative about women overcoming barriers. They are business stories about how organisations grow, professionalise and prepare for more complex demands.

The emerging industries these women operate in may be defined by drones, defence electronics, advanced systems or new service models. But beneath the technology is a more enduring task, building companies that can execute consistently, learn as they expand, and function beyond the instincts or energy of any single leader. BT

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"One thing I've learnt is that you cannot wait for someone to give you authority. You have to own it"

RITHIKA MOHAN
CO-FOUNDER AND CHIEF ADMINISTRATIVE OFFICER, GARUDA AEROSPACE



"Men are always recruited for potential. Women have to prove it. Women are recruited with proof"

REKHA MURTHY RANGARAJAN
WHOLE-TIME DIRECTOR AT DATA PATTERNS